Learnify : Product Assessment and Case study

Reducing Drop-offs in a Gamified Learning App Through Story based Motivation Progress

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1. Define the Problem

1A. Problem statement

Learnify has strong initial sign-up and 70% of students drop off after completing Lesson 3. Feedback says current rewards are not motivating enough. The case gives us the symptom, not the root cause.

1B. What we know vs. assumptions

We know	We need to validate
70% drop-off occurs after Lesson 3	Is reward design actually the cause?
Students report rewards feel unmotivating	Is Lesson 4 harder, longer, or less relevant?
Current loop uses badges, levels, leaderboards	Has novelty worn off, or is there weak return intent?

1C. Three critical motivation metrics

Metric	What it captures	Why it matters
Lesson 4 completion rate · PRIMARY	% of students who finish the lesson at the drop-off point and go on to finish the one right after it — Lesson 4 in this dataset, but the metric generalizes to wherever the funnel actually breaks.	Directly measures the broken transition
D7 unprompted learning return	% of students who come back and complete a meaningful learning action within 7 days of Lesson 3	Checks durability beyond novelty
Voluntary re-engagement	% of students who resume a lesson without a notification reminder	Behavioral signal of genuine value, not just prompting

INSIGHT → OPPORTUNITY	Move from “How do we make the reward more exciting?” to “What would make the next lesson worth opening?”

1D. Why the current reward loop stops working

Hypothesis	Reasoning
Rewards became predictable	The same badge/level pattern every time removes the anticipation that made it exciting the first few times.
Rewards don't feel personally meaningful	A badge confirms a lesson is done — it doesn't tell a student *why that mattered* or connect to anything they chose.
Nothing creates a reason to open the next lesson specifically.	The system rewards what was just finished, not what's coming — so there's no forward pull.

2. Proposed Feature Enhancement

2A. Story Threads

PROPOSAL	Turn each subject into a short, student-owned narrative. Every lesson is the next scene — so the reason to keep learning is the same as the reason to keep reading.

Typical approach	Story Threads
Reward is generic — points, badge, box	Reward is narrative progress in a story the student chose
Reward appears after the lesson, disconnected from it	The lesson is the next chapter — reward and learning are one action
Motivation source: randomness or competition	Motivation source: curiosity and unresolved narrative tension
Identical experience for every student	Track choice + one end-of-chapter decision give real autonomy

2B. Why this mechanism

Cliffhanger	One real choice	Track, not profile	Progression
Each chapter ends mid-scene, tied to the lesson's concept — not to a countdown or random reveal.	Students pick how the story continues — narrative only, never a shortcut on difficulty.	Students pick a theme at onboarding (space / mystery / expedition). No behavioral profiling behind it in the MVP.	Reward = the story moving forward. Nothing is collected, ranked, or displayed publicly.

2C. Alternatives considered

Mechanism	Strength	Key risk	Decision
Mystery Boxes	Surprise; easy to understand	Randomness can become the motivation	Useful as a future cosmetic layer, not the core loop
Leaderboards	Social energy	Comparison can demotivate students already behind	Do not use for this intervention
Story Threads	Curiosity + learning linked progression	Narrative can distract or add content cost	Test as the core intervention

2D. Feature scope

Lesson 3 complete Chapter ends on a cliffhanger tied to the concept just taught.	**Teaser cliffhanger** 20-second illustrated scene. No lesson content yet — pure hook.	**Lesson 4, in-story** Same curriculum, framed inside the scene the student is curious about.	4 **Resolution + choice** Cliffhanger resolves. One narrative choice —, never difficulty.	5 **Return** Tomorrow opens on the scene their choice created.

3. Detailed User Journey

3A. End-to-end journey

Lesson 3 complete	Chapter Teaser Cliffhanger	Lesson 4 in-story	Resolution+ choice	Return next day

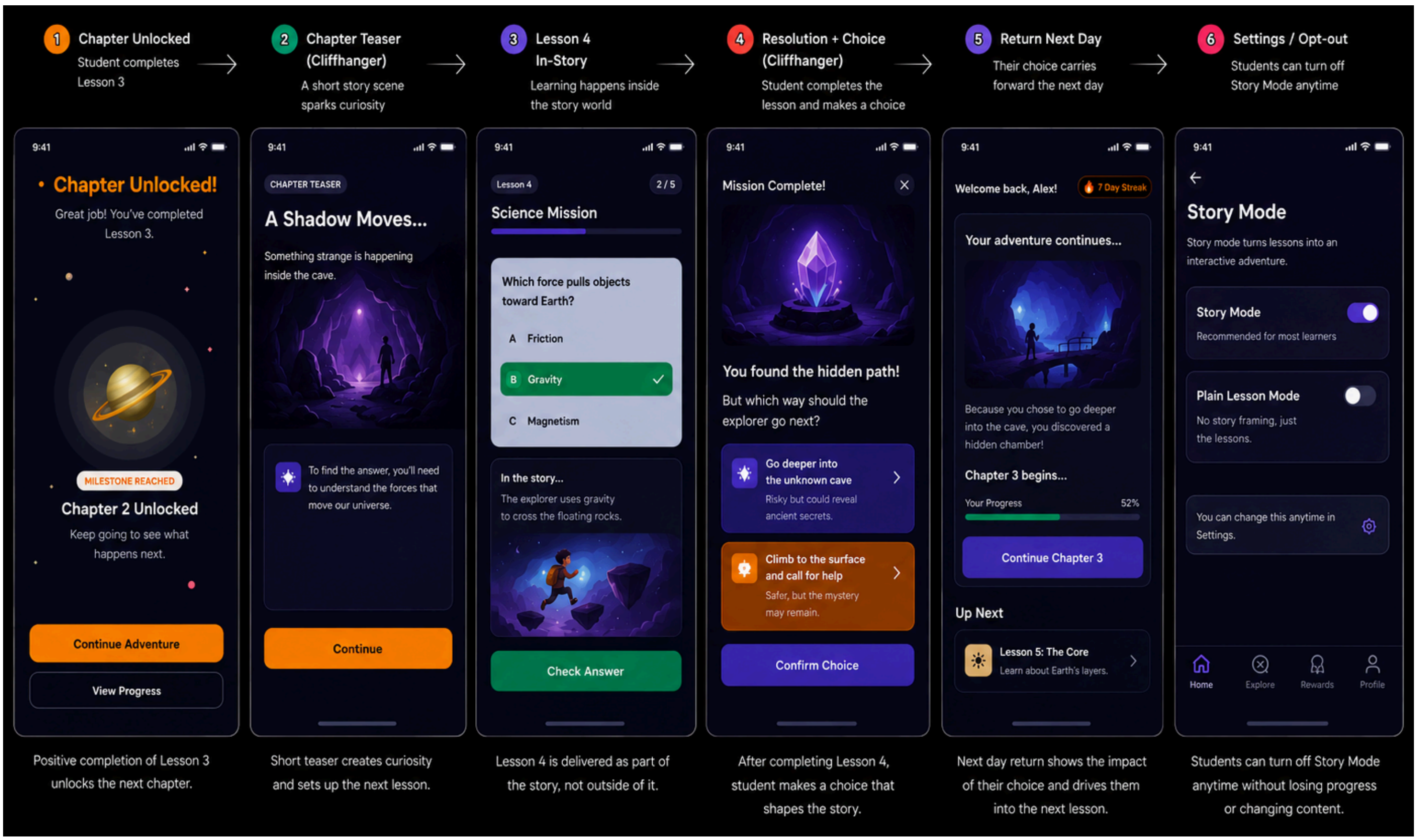
Student / Action / System / Emotion

Stage	Student sees	Action	System response	Emotion
Lesson 3 complete	“A shadow moves…”	Taps continue	Loads cliffhanger	Curious
Cliffhanger	20-sec scene ending mid-action	Watches / reads	Holds unresolved moment	Hooked
Lesson 4 in-story	Curriculum questions inside scene	Completes lesson	Unlocks resolution	Focused
Choice	Two narrative options	Picks one	Saves choice + previews next chapter	In control

Stage	Student sees	Action	System response	Emotion
Return	Opening reflects prior choice	Opens app	Chapter continues	Anticipating

3B. CRITICAL MOMENT	**Current :** Badge / points / leaderboard → reward is separate from learning **Story Threads:** Next chapter → **the learning progress itself becomes the reward**

3C. User journey Mockup /Wireframe Screens



https://www.figma.com/design/ZSy1RY6MG390ZAvEblYfAg/Learnify_mockscreen?node-id=0-1&t=oHtP6hUFf8NQ4Jbs-1

What the screens prove is Curiosity after Lesson 3, learning remains central ,agency without academic manipulation and a concrete return hook.

Design Principles + Guardrails

3D. Design principles

Principle	Rule
Learning first	The story wraps around the lesson; it never blocks or slows it.
One clear CTA	One primary action per screen; progress to the next chapter remains visible.
Choice without manipulation	Choices affect narrative/cosmetics, never difficulty, grades, or access.
Story framing can be turned off	student who doesn't want narrative gets the plain lesson — same content, same progress, no penalty

3E. Product / learning guardrails

Risk	Watch	Failure signal
Students rush lessons	Quiz accuracy + time-on-task	Completion rises while accuracy falls
Story distracts from learning	Lesson quality / skip rate	Story engagement rises but learning quality falls
Binge-style use	Session length	Large session-duration increase
Feature feels annoying	Dismiss / negative feedback rate	Repeated opt-outs or complaints
Works only for one segment	Grade, subject, baseline engagement	Lift concentrated in a narrow cohort

The product should earn return visits through curiosity and value — not pressure, randomness, or public comparison.

4. A/B Testing Plan

4A. Hypothesis

HYPOTHESIS	If we replace the generic post-Lesson 3 reward with a student-chosen narrative cliffhanger, Lesson 4 and moving next lesson completion will increase because students now have a personally relevant reason to continue.because the next lesson resolves something they're personally invested in.

4B. Control A vs. Experiment B

Control · A	Experiment · B
Lesson 3 → standard badge / level-up	Lesson 3 → cliffhanger + choice
Lesson 4 opens normally	Lesson 4 is framed and delivered inside the story
No narrative resolution	Lesson completion unlocks narrative resolution choice

4C. Primary / Secondary / Guardrail metrics

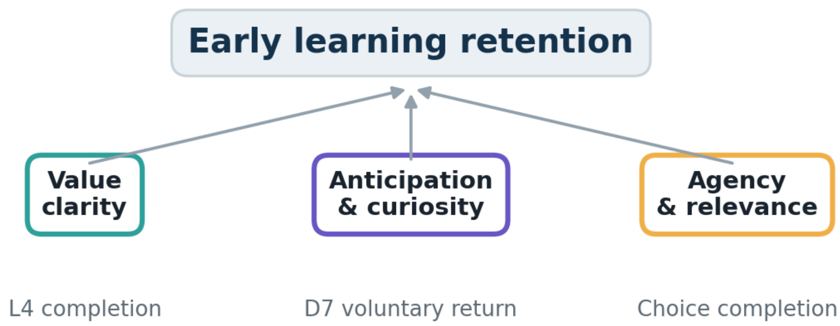
Priority	Metric
PRIMARY	Next-lesson completion rate (the lesson immediately after the observed drop-off — Lesson 4 here)
SECONDARY	Day-7 return rate · voluntary re-engagement rate · chapters completed per active learner
GUARDRAILS	Quiz accuracy · lesson completion quality · session length · negative feedback rate

4D. Randomization + observation period

Item	Design
Population	Students who have just completed Lesson 3
Assignment	50/50, assigned at the user level, so each student sees only one experience.
Observation	Minimum 14 days, or until the pre-calculated sample size is reached
Success	Meaningful primary-metric lift without material guardrail deterioration

4. Experimentation & Product Decision

4E. Instrumentation



Event	Why capture it
lesson_completed	Establishes the Lesson 3 starting cohort
story_viewed	Measures whether the hook is noticed
story_choice_made	Measures agency / completion of the story step
lesson_4_started	Captures conversion into the target behavior
lesson_4_completed	Primary outcome
voluntary_return	Checks durability beyond prompts

4F. Ship / Iterate / Stop

Decision	Rule
SHIP	Lesson 4 completion improves and learning-quality guardrails remain stable.
ITERATE	Lift is weak, inconsistent, or concentrated in one story track / segment.
STOP	No meaningful lift, or engagement rises while a key learning guardrail worsens.

4G. MVP → Next iteration

- MVP proves: does narrative curiosity improve the Lesson 3 → 4 transition?
- Next: expand successful themes / subjects and test richer choices only after the core loop works.

Thus, Prototype quickly. Test narrowly. Scale only with evidence.

4. Product Risks, Rollout & Next Steps

4H. Key risks

Risk	Detection	Response
Students rush lessons to unlock story	Accuracy / time-on-task worsen	Shorten story friction; tighten lesson integration
Novelty wears off	D7 lift disappears	Introduce new arcs only after validating core value
Content cost becomes too high	Authoring time per chapter	Use reusable story frameworks
Works for only one learner segment	Lift varies sharply by cohort	Simplify themes and validate segment fit before scaling

4I. Rollout plan

Phase	Focus	Gate
1 · Prototype	One subject, one story track, 3–4 chapters	Students understand the flow and can complete lessons normally
2 · Experiment	50/50 test at Lesson 3 → 4	Primary metric + guardrails meet pre-set criteria
3 · Validate	Check durability and segment fit	D7 behavior supports a lasting effect
4 · Scale	Add themes / subjects	Evidence supports repeatability and content economics

4J. What I would build next — and what I would not

Next	Not yet
More story themes / subjects	Public leaderboards
Richer narrative choices	Randomized loot / paid rewards
Lightweight personalization	Complex adaptive branching

5. Expected Outcome and Conclusion

We are not making the reward more exciting. **We are making the next lesson worth opening.** By connecting learning with curiosity and meaningful progress, we aim for **higher next-lesson completion and stronger 7-day retention — then prove it through the Lesson 3 → 4 transition.**